Lesson Plan: From Harmful Narratives to Counter-Narratives

Description of the lesson

The lesson introduces participants to the concept of narratives and counter-narratives as tools for understanding, challenging and transforming harmful messages in media, politics and digital communication. It explores how dominant narratives shape public perceptions of social issues, how they can justify discrimination, violence or exclusion, and how counter-narratives can be used to restore dignity, provide context and promote human rights.

Through discussion, examples and group work, participants analyse how harmful narratives appear in media headlines, social media posts, comments and public discourse. They learn how to identify emotional triggers such as fear, anger, disgust, humiliation, status threat and distrust, and how these emotions are often used to manipulate audiences or mobilise hostility toward marginalised groups.

The lesson also focuses on practical strategies for creating effective counter-narratives. Participants learn how to expose manipulation, introduce facts and context, shift perspective, protect the dignity of victims and marginalised groups, and reframe the conversation around human rights, equality and social responsibility.

The lesson uses examples related to sexism, gender-based violence, racism, homophobia, transphobia and extremism. It can be adapted depending on the national context by using locally relevant examples of harmful media reporting, discriminatory public discourse, online hate speech or activist counter-narrative campaigns.

Learning objectives

By the end of the lesson, participants will be able to:

· understand the difference between a narrative and a counter-narrative;
· identify emotional triggers used in harmful narratives, such as fear, anger, disgust, humiliation and distrust;
· analyse how counter-narratives can expose manipulation, provide facts, shift perspective and defend human rights;
· distinguish between an effective counter-narrative and an insult, personal attack, deflection or empty sarcasm;
· develop a basic counter-narrative message responding to a harmful narrative in media or online communication;

Target group

The lesson is intended for young people participating in a non-formal education programme focused on civic, media and digital competences. It is especially relevant for young people who are active online, engage with social and political content, participate in comment sections or social media discussions, or are interested in using digital communication for social change.

The lesson can also be adapted for school classes, youth groups, student organisations, young activists or participants with less prior experience in media analysis and content creation.

Duration

Approximately 90 minutes.

Learning outcomes, content, teaching and learning methods, and evaluation methods

Learning outcomes	Content	Teaching and learning methods	Evaluation methods
Explain the difference between narratives and counter-narratives	Narratives as stories that shape how society understands problems, victims, responsibility and solutions; counter-narratives as deliberate messages that challenge harmful dominant narratives	Short input; guided discussion; analysis of examples	Oral reflection; facilitator questions
Identify harmful narratives and the emotions they activate	Fear, anger, disgust, humiliation, status threat, loss of control, conspiracy and distrust; how emotional triggers reduce critical thinking and mobilise hostility	Presentation; example analysis; pair work	Group discussion; completed analysis task
Analyse the elements of an effective counter-narrative	Exposing manipulation; providing facts; shifting perspective; restoring dignity; reframing toward human rights, equality and responsibility	Workshop; small group work; case study analysis	Group presentation; peer feedback

Lesson structure

1. Introduction: What stories shape our reality?

Duration: 10 minutes

The facilitator opens the session with a short introduction of the “Center for Civil Initiatives Poreč” wich is a feminist, human rights, peacebuilding and non-profit civil society organization, guided by the principles of freedom, equality and non-discrimination, and has been protecting and promoting human rights and active citizenship since 1992.

After that, the facilitator leans in to leading a short discussion that starts with these questions:

· Where do we encounter social and political “stories” every day?
· Can media headlines, social media posts or comments influence how we understand certain groups of people?
· Can a story make someone appear guilty, dangerous, invisible or less worthy of empathy?
· Have you ever seen a post or comment that challenged a harmful stereotype or false claim?

The aim is to activate participants’ prior knowledge and introduce the idea that narratives are not neutral. They shape what society sees as the problem, who is blamed, who is recognised as a victim and what is considered a possible solution.

2. Input: What is a counter-narrative?

Duration: 20 minutes

The facilitator introduces the main concepts:

· narratives as dominant stories that shape public understanding;
· harmful narratives that justify discrimination, violence or exclusion;
· counter-narratives as deliberately crafted messages that challenge or overturn harmful narratives;
· the difference between a counter-narrative and a simple opposing opinion;
· the social and educational function of counter-narratives;
· examples of counter-narratives in comments, social media posts, visuals, campaigns, public statements, media analyses and advocacy.

The facilitator explains that a counter-narrative can:

· expose manipulation;
· provide facts and context;
· shift perspective;
· defend the dignity and rights of marginalised groups;
· reframe the issue around justice, equality and responsibility.

Key message: counter-narratives matter because narratives shape reality. If harmful narratives remain unquestioned, they can become normalised.

3. Case study "Everyday sexism": From harmful media reporting to counter-narrative

Duration: 25 minutes

Participants analyse an example of harmful media reporting or online communication. The example may relate to gender-based violence, sexism, racism, homophobia, transphobia, migration, extremism or another issue relevant to the national context.

The facilitator guides participants through the analysis.

Guiding questions:

· What is the dominant narrative in this example?
· Who is being blamed, erased, dehumanised or misrepresented?
· Which emotional trigger is being used?
· Does the message rely on fear, anger, disgust, humiliation or distrust?
· What facts or context are missing?
· How could the message be reframed in a way that protects dignity and human rights?
· What would an effective counter-narrative look like?

The facilitator encourages participants to notice not only what is said, but also what is left unsaid. For example, harmful reporting may focus on gossip, private details or the perpetrator's emotions while ignoring structural violence, institutional responsibility, victim dignity or available support.

4. Group activity: Building a counter-narrative

Duration: 25 minutes

Participants work in small groups. Each group receives one harmful narrative, headline, comment, post or scenario.

Their task is to develop a short counter-narrative by following five steps:

1. **Identify the harmful narrative**
   What is being said? What message is being spread? Which emotion is being activated?
2. **Name the harm**
   Who is being blamed, dehumanised, misrepresented or erased?
3. **Introduce facts and context**
   What information, research, social pattern or expert knowledge is missing?

4. **Reframe the focus**
   How can the message shift responsibility back to perpetrators, systems or structures instead of blaming victims or marginalised groups?
5. **Close with values**
   Which values should guide the response - dignity, equality, justice, safety, freedom, human rights or democratic responsibility?

Each group prepares a short response in one of the following formats:

· social media comment;
· Instagram caption;
· short video script;
· poster headline;
· campaign slogan;
· carousel post concept.

Participants are reminded that an effective counter-narrative is not an insult, personal attack, "whataboutism" or sarcasm without substance. It should be clear, fact-based, accessible and respectful of human dignity.

Each group briefly presents its counter-narrative.

5. Reflection and closing

Duration: 10 minutes

The facilitator closes the lesson with reflection questions:

· Why do harmful narratives often spread so quickly online?
· What makes a counter-narrative effective?
· When can a response become harmful, even if the intention is good?
· How can we challenge harmful narratives without reproducing hate or misinformation?
· What can young people do after this training - online and offline?

Participants share one key takeaway from the lesson.

Materials for teaching

Material	**Form**
Presentation: From Hate to Change – Counter-Narratives in Action	Presentation
Examples of harmful narratives, headlines, posts or comments	Digital examples

Counter-narrative analysis and template for building a counter-narrative worksheet	Worksheet
Laptop, projector and internet connection	Technical equipment

Evaluation of the lesson

Evaluation is carried out through a combination of discussion, group work and short reflection.